That sounded silly. But, well, there it was.

Most memories of my mother, I explained, with sudden and overwhelming sorrow, were gone. On the other side of the Wall. I told her about the Wall. I told her I'd spoken to Willy about my lack of memories of our mother. He'd advised me to look through photo albums, which I'd promptly done. Nothing.

So, my mother wasn't images, or impressions, she was mainly just a hole in my heart, and if I healed that hole, patched it up—what then?

I asked if all this sounded crazy.

No.

We were silent.

A long time.

She asked me what I needed. *Why are you here?*

Look, I said. *What I need…is to be rid of this heaviness in my chest. I need… I need…*

Yes?

To cry. Please. Help me cry.

26.

THE NEXT SESSION I asked if it would be all right for me to lie down.

She smiled. *I was wondering when you'd ask.*

I stretched out on the green sofa, tucked a pillow under my neck.

I spoke about the physical and emotional suffering. The panic, the anxiety. The sweats.

How long has this been going on?

Two or three years now. It used to be much worse.

I told her about the talk with Cress. During the skiing holiday. The top coming off the bottle, emotions fizzing all over the place. I'd cried a bit then… but it wasn't enough. I needed to cry more. And I couldn't.

I got around to talking about the deep rage, the ostensible trigger for seeking her out in the first place. I described the scene with Meg, in the kitchen.

I shook my head.